

The Complete Malaysian Parent Guide: "I Think My Child Might Be Autistic. What Do I Do?"

CJ Lim | Autism Pathways Consulting | 2026

Please read this first. This guide helps you take the right steps. It does not replace a proper assessment by a doctor or trained professional. Only a licensed doctor or clinical psychologist can formally diagnose autism. Use this guide to know where to go and what to ask.

This guide covers:

- What signs to look for in your child
- How to get a free developmental screening (no appointment needed)
- What to say to get a referral to a specialist
- How to start therapy before a diagnosis
- How to protect your child from unqualified therapists

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SECTION 1

Signs to Watch For

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SECTION 1 -- Signs to Watch For

Based on the DSM-5-TR (American Psychiatric Association, 2022) -- the international diagnostic standard

How to use this section: The signs below are grouped into two areas. If your child shows signs from Area A (all three groups) AND at least two signs from Area B, it is worth getting a professional assessment. Seeing these signs does not mean your child has autism. It means a professional should take a closer look. The earlier you go, the better.

Area A -- How Your Child Communicates and Connects with Others

Watch for signs in all three groups below. All three groups need to show some signs for this area to apply.

A1 Back-and-forth communication	• Does not respond when you call their name • Rarely makes eye contact with people they know • Does not share what they are interested in (for example, pointing at something to show you) • Does not copy what other people do or say • Hard to have a back-and-forth "conversation," even non-verbally
A2 Using body and face to communicate	• Uses very few or no gestures (waving, pointing, nodding) • Facial expressions may not match the situation • Avoids eye contact, or eye contact feels "different" • Does not seem to understand facial expressions or body language in others
A3 Friendships and play with others	• Not interested in playing with other children their age • Plays alongside others but rarely interacts with them (no sharing, no turn-taking) • Does not adjust how they behave in different situations (same tone with everyone) • Does not engage in pretend or imaginative play

Area B -- Patterns of Behaviour, Interests, and Senses

Look for signs in at least 2 of the 4 groups below for this area to apply.

B1 Repetitive movements or speech	• Flaps hands, rocks body, spins, or flicks fingers repeatedly • Repeats words or phrases they have heard, sometimes from TV (called echolalia) • Lines up toys or objects instead of playing with them • Repeats the same action or uses objects in an unusual, repetitive way
B2 Need for sameness and routine	• Gets very upset when small things change (a different route, a moved object) • Insists on doing things in exactly the same way every time • Has very rigid thinking -- finds it hard to accept new ideas or changes • Has specific rituals around greetings, meals, or transitions
B3 Very intense specific interests	• Extremely focused on one or two topics to an unusual degree • Strong attachment to a specific unusual object • Knows far more about one topic than expected for their age
B4 Unusual responses to senses	• Seems not to feel pain or temperature as strongly as others • Covers ears for sounds that do not bother others • Very bothered by certain textures of clothing or food • Seeks out very strong sensory experiences (pressing, spinning, smelling objects) • Fascinated by lights, moving objects, or patterns

Source: DSM-5-TR, American Psychiatric Association, 2022. Signs must be present from early childhood, cause real difficulty in daily life, and cannot be explained by another condition.

SECTION 2

What to Do Next: Your Step-by-Step Plan

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SECTION 2 -- What to Do Next: Your Step-by-Step Plan

STEP 01 Go to Your Nearest Klinik Kesihatan (Government Health Clinic)

Free. No appointment or referral letter needed. Walk in.

What to say at the counter	"I am concerned about my child's development. I would like to request a developmental screening."
What happens next	A doctor or nurse will give your child a short developmental screening. This is a set of questions about your child's development -- it takes about 10 minutes. It is completely free.
What to bring	Your child's health booklet (buku kesihatan kanak-kanak), your child, any notes or videos you have of your concerns.
An important note	Klinik Kesihatan offers developmental checks when your child is 18 months old and again at 3 years old. But you do not have to wait for these scheduled dates. If you are worried right now, you can walk in and ask for a developmental check at any time.
If the doctor dismisses you	"I would like my concerns to be written in my child's file. Can we set a follow-up appointment to check on my child's development?"

STEP 02 Ask for a Referral to a Developmental Paediatrician

A Developmental Paediatrician is a doctor who specialises in children's development and can diagnose autism.

Who can formally diagnose autism	In Malaysia, an autism diagnosis can only be made by a licensed doctor specialising in child development (called a Developmental Paediatrician) or a licensed Clinical Psychologist. Both are registered with the Malaysian government.
What to say	"Can I have a referral letter to see a Developmental Paediatrician at [name of government hospital]? I am concerned my child might have autism."
Government hospitals (free with referral)	Hospital Tunku Azizah (Kuala Lumpur), Hospital UKM (Cheras, KL), Hospital Putrajaya, Hospital Raja Perempuan Zainab II (Kota Bharu, Kelantan), Hospital Sultanah Aminah (Johor Bahru), Hospital Pulau Pinang, Hospital Likas (Kota Kinabalu, Sabah), Hospital Queen Elizabeth (Sabah).
How long is the wait	Government hospitals: 3 to 18 months depending on location. This is normal. Submit your referral and then immediately start Step 3 while you wait.
Private option (faster, costs more)	Private doctors and psychologists can usually see your child within 1 to 4 weeks. Estimated cost: RM800 to RM3,000 or more for a full assessment. Both government and private diagnoses are fully accepted by schools and government agencies.

STEP 03 Start Speech Therapy Now -- Do Not Wait for a Diagnosis

You do not need a formal autism diagnosis to begin therapy.

Why start before you have a diagnosis	A child's brain develops fastest before the age of 5. Every month of early support makes a real difference. Starting therapy while you wait for a diagnosis is not just acceptable -- it is recommended.
At a government hospital (free)	Ask your doctor at Klinik Kesihatan or the Developmental Paediatrician for a referral to a Speech Therapist at the same hospital. This is free but may have a waiting list.
At a private clinic (faster)	A qualified Speech Therapist holds at least a degree in Speech Sciences or Speech Pathology. To find one near you, visit: mash.org.my (the professional body for Speech Therapists in Malaysia). Estimated cost: RM150 to RM400 per session.
Occupational Therapy (if sensory concerns)	If your child has strong sensory reactions, an Occupational Therapist (OT) can also help. Occupational Therapists help children with daily skills, sensory regulation, and school readiness. To find one, visit: ot-malaysia.my Estimated cost: RM150 to RM350 per session.
Centre-based programmes	Some families use early intervention centres that offer therapy, social skills, and school preparation. Estimated cost: RM1,500 to RM4,000 per month. Government services are free with a referral but have longer wait times.

STEP 04 Start Documenting Your Child's Behaviour Today

Your notes and videos are powerful tools at every appointment.

Short video clips	Record 1 to 2 minute clips of: your child playing on their own, responding (or not responding) when you call their name, and interacting with other children or adults. Write the date on each clip.
Written notes	Keep a simple note on your phone. Write specific things you notice, with the date. Example: "23 April -- called his name 5 times, no response."
Questions for the doctor	Write down every question you want to ask before each appointment. It is easy to forget important questions under the pressure of a clinic visit.
Why this matters	Doctors make faster and better decisions when parents bring real evidence. Your documentation directly improves the quality of care your child receives.

A note on behaviour therapy (ABA): If someone recommends ABA (Applied Behaviour Analysis) therapy, ask who supervises the therapist and what training framework they use. The international standard is a BCBA (Board Certified Behaviour Analyst). Ask if the therapist is BCBA-certified or supervised by a BCBA. You can verify at bacb.com. This profession is not yet regulated by law in Malaysia, so asking this question protects your child.

SECTION 3

Government vs Private: What to Expect

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SECTION 3 -- Government vs Private: What to Expect

	Government (Free)	Private (Faster)
Full autism assessment	Free (subsidised by government)	Estimated RM800 to RM3,000+
Waiting time for assessment	3 to 18 months	1 to 4 weeks
Speech therapy sessions	Free with doctor's referral	Estimated RM150 to RM400 per session
Occupational therapy sessions	Free with doctor's referral	Estimated RM150 to RM350 per session
Early intervention programme	Limited -- not available everywhere	Estimated RM1,500 to RM4,000 per month
Is the diagnosis accepted by schools and government?	Yes -- fully accepted	Yes -- fully accepted
What we recommend	Submit your referral immediately. Do not wait to "see what happens first."	Use private services while waiting for your government appointment. Do not delay starting therapy.

SECTION 4

How to Choose a Therapist Safely

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SECTION 4 -- How to Choose a Therapist Safely

Ask these questions before you commit to any private therapist or centre

In Malaysia, some people offer "autism therapy" or "special needs support" without proper qualifications. This is more common in private settings. An unqualified person can waste your money, delay real help, and in some cases cause harm to your child. Use the information below to protect your family.

Professional	What they do	Minimum qualification	How to check	Watch out for
Doctor who diagnoses autism (Developmental Paediatrician)	Assesses your child and gives a formal autism diagnosis	Medical degree (MBBS or MD) plus specialist training in child development	Ask for their full name and clinic. Verify at mmc.gov.my (Malaysian Medical Council)	No medical degree. Cannot tell you where they are registered. Not attached to a licensed clinic.
Clinical Psychologist	Can assess and diagnose autism. Provides therapy and counselling.	Masters or PhD in Clinical Psychology (not just a bachelor's degree)	Ask: "Are you registered with the Malaysian Allied Health Professions Council? What is your registration number?"	Only has a basic psychology degree. Cannot give you a registration number. Vague about qualifications.
Speech Therapist (also called Speech-Language Therapist)	Helps your child develop communication and language skills	University degree in Speech Sciences or Speech Pathology	Ask for their registration number with MAHPC. Also check mash.org.my	No degree in Speech Sciences. Cannot give a registration number. Offers "speech therapy" as part of an unrelated service.
Occupational Therapist	Helps with sensory processing, daily life skills, fine motor skills, school readiness	University degree in Occupational Therapy	Ask for MAHPC registration number. Also check ot-malaysia.my	No degree in OT. Cannot give a registration number.
Behaviour Therapist (ABA Therapist)	Uses structured techniques to build communication, behaviour, and learning skills	Internationally, the gold standard is BCBA (Board Certified Behaviour Analyst). In Malaysia, this profession is not yet regulated by law.	Ask if they are BCBA-certified or supervised by a BCBA. Verify at bacb.com . Reputable centres use BCBA-supervised programmes. If not BCBA-certified, ask who supervises the therapist and what training framework they use.	No BCBA certification or supervision. Promises to "cure" autism. Pressures you to commit to long or expensive packages immediately.

SECTION 4 -- Stop Immediately and Walk Away If...

Stop immediately and walk away if any of the following happen:

- Claims they can "cure" or "reverse" autism
- Cannot clearly explain their qualifications when you ask
- Pressures you to sign up for a long programme or pay a large amount upfront before you have seen results
- Tells you that you do not need a formal diagnosis from a doctor
- Promotes special diets, supplements, or unusual treatments as the main therapy
- Does not give you written goals or a progress report for your child
- Will not allow you to observe or be present during therapy sessions with your child

SECTION 5

Exactly What to Say at Each Appointment

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SECTION 5 -- Exactly What to Say at Each Appointment

At the Klinik Kesihatan

"I am worried about my child's development. Can I request a developmental screening today? My child is [age] years old."

Asking for a hospital referral

"Can I have a referral letter to see a Developmental Paediatrician at [hospital name]? I am worried that my child might have autism."

At the specialist appointment

"My child is [age]. I am concerned about [describe 2 to 3 specific things you have noticed]. I have been writing notes since [date] and I have some video clips I can show you."

Starting Speech Therapy before a diagnosis

"My child is [age] and is not yet speaking, or has very limited speech. I am waiting for a specialist appointment. I would like to start speech therapy now. Do I need a referral?"

Checking a therapist's credentials

"Are you registered with the Malaysian Allied Health Professions Council? Can you give me your registration number? I would like to verify it."

If the doctor does not take you seriously

"I would like my concerns to be written in my child's medical file. Can we schedule a follow-up in four weeks to review my child's development?"

If someone promises to cure autism

"Thank you, but I am looking for evidence-based therapy that supports my child's communication and daily skills. Can you show me the research behind what you are offering?"

SECTION 6

Organisations That Can Help You in Malaysia

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SECTION 6 -- Organisations That Can Help You in Malaysia

NASOM (National Autism Society of Malaysia)	Provides early intervention programmes, therapy, school support, and parent guidance nationwide. One of the most established autism organisations in Malaysia.	nasom.org.my
MASH (Malaysian Association of Speech-Language and Hearing)	The professional body for Speech Therapists in Malaysia. Use their website to find a qualified Speech Therapist near you, or to check if a therapist is properly registered.	mash.org.my thesecretary@mash.org.my
OT Malaysia (Malaysian Occupational Therapy Association)	The professional body for Occupational Therapists in Malaysia. Use their website to find a qualified Occupational Therapist near you, or to verify a therapist's registration.	ot-malaysia.my
MAHPC (Malaysian Allied Health Professions Council)	The government body that registers Speech Therapists, Occupational Therapists, Clinical Psychologists, and other health professionals in Malaysia. Contact them to check if a professional is properly registered.	alliedhealth.moh.gov.my Tel: 03-8890 1011
MMC (Malaysian Medical Council)	The government body that registers all doctors in Malaysia. Use their website to verify any doctor, including Developmental Paediatricians.	mmc.gov.my
MARF (Malaysian Autism Research Foundation)	Provides research-based information and a directory of support professionals for Malaysian families.	marf.org.my
JKM (Jabatan Kebajikan Masyarakat)	Government agency for social welfare. Handles OKU card registration (for persons with disabilities), financial assistance, and community rehabilitation programmes (PDK) nationwide.	jkm.gov.my

For information only. Not medical advice. Sources: DSM-5-TR (APA, 2022) | Allied Health Professions Act 774 (Malaysia, 2016) | Malaysian Paediatric Association / CodeBlue (Feb 2025) | Jasminde Kaur et al., Autism Research (Mar 2024)

CHECKLIST

Bring This Page To Every Appointment

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AUTISM PATHWAYS CONSULTING First Steps Checklist

@autismpathwaysconsulting | Print this page. Tick each box as you go. Bring it to every appointment.

STEP 1 -- KLINIK KESIHATAN (FREE, NO APPOINTMENT NEEDED)

- Go to the nearest Klinik Kesihatan.
 - Say: "I am worried about my child's development. Can I request a developmental screening?"
 - Bring: health booklet, your child, your written observations or video clips.
- Date: _____ Screening done. Result / next steps told to me:

- Date: _____ Referral letter to Developmental Paediatrician received.

STEP 2 -- SEE A DEVELOPMENTAL PAEDIATRICIAN (DOCTOR SPECIALISING IN CHILD DEVELOPMENT)

- Referral submitted to government hospital.
- Hospital: _____ Appointment date:

- Prepared video clips and written notes before appointment.
 - Said at appointment: "My concerns are [specific observations]. I have documentation."
- Date: _____ Formal assessment done. Report received.

STEP 3 -- START THERAPY NOW (NO DIAGNOSIS NEEDED)

- Speech Therapist found. Name: _____ Registration verified: yes / no
 - Checked therapist is registered (mash.org.my or alliedhealth.moh.gov.my)
- Date: _____ Speech therapy started. Clinic / therapist name:

AUTISM PATHWAYS CONSULTING First Steps Checklist

@autismpathwaysconsulting | Type your answers directly into this PDF, or print and fill by hand.

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- Go to the nearest Klinik Kesihatan.
 - Say: "I am worried about my child's development. Can I request a developmental screening?"
 - Bring: health booklet, your child, your written observations or video clips.
- Date: _____ Screening done. Result / next steps: _____
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- Referral submitted to government hospital.
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- Prepared video clips and written notes before appointment.
 - Said at appointment: "My concerns are [specific observations]. I have documentation."
- Date: _____ Formal assessment done. Report received.

STEP 3 -- START THERAPY NOW (NO DIAGNOSIS NEEDED)

- Speech Therapist found. Name: _____ Registration verified: _____
 - Checked therapist is registered (mash.org.my or alliedhealth.moh.gov.my)
- Date: _____ Speech therapy started. Clinic / therapist name: _____
- Occupational Therapist needed? If yes, found one and verified at ot-malaysia.my
 - Confirmed: no cure promised, written goals agreed, can observe sessions.

STEP 4 -- DOCUMENT EVERYTHING

- Video folder created on phone. Each clip is dated and labelled.
- Written notes started. Each entry has a date and specific observation.
- Questions list written and ready for next appointment.

STEP 5 -- VERIFY CREDENTIALS (PROTECT YOUR CHILD)

- Asked every private professional for their registration number with the Malaysian Allied Health Professions Council.
- Checked doctors at mmc.gov.my | Speech Therapists at mash.org.my | OTs at ot-malaysia.my
- Did not accept any promises of "cure." Walked away from pressure selling.

NEXT STEPS

Continue With APC Support

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"You don't have to wait for the system to come to you. Walk in. Ask the right questions. You now have them."

Every family that walks through the right door earlier gives their child more time in the window that matters most. You are already ahead by knowing what to do.

APC Calm Companion (Free Tool)

A free mobile-friendly support tool designed to help parents during meltdowns, routines, transitions, communication breakdowns, and difficult moments.

[Open Free Tool](#)

Free 15-Minute Discovery Call

A supportive first conversation to understand your child's needs and discuss suitable next steps for your family.

[Book Discovery Call](#)

1:1 Parent Support & Strategy Session

A focused 45-minute strategy session for parents seeking practical, evidence-based support tailored to their child and family situation.

[View Parent Support Session](#)

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